

ARCHITECTURE/ROBERT CAMPBELL

Yale sums up state of the art

As just about every architect knows, the Yale Math Building competition was held in 1970 and won by Venturi and Rauch of Philadelphia, a firm that is led by Robert Venturi, the most infuriating and controversial architectural propagandist of recent years.

It was Venturi who said buildings should be "ugly and ordinary" instead of beautiful and special, and who, in books and articles, sang the delights of A&P parking lots and the Las Vegas Strip.

Among his proposals was the suggestion that Boston City Hall might more appropriately have been designed, not as the expressive, distinctive, somewhat distorted sculptural form that it is now, but rather as a cheap, workable box with a huge neon billboard on top reading, "I AM A MONUMENT."

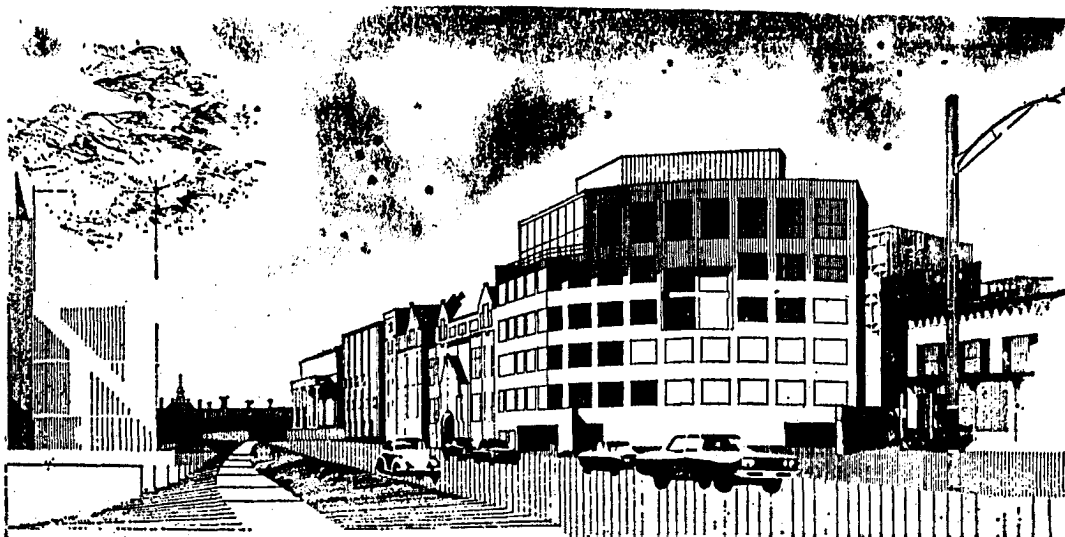
With a winner like that, it's not surprising that the Yale competition stirred up a lot of interest, not to mention anger and paranoia, especially since Venturi and Rauch had built almost nothing at the time. To many, their winning design for the building that was to house Yale's Mathematics Department — chosen from among 468 entries — looked, indeed, ugly and ordinary.

The recession hit the economy and the building never was built, at least not yet. Tempers have cooled and the time is ripe for assessment of a competition that seems likely to prove a landmark in the architectural history of our time. This is now provided in a new book, "The Yale Mathematics Building Competition: Architecture for a Time of Questioning," edited by Charles Moore and Nicholas Pyle (Yale University Press, \$15.) It's a little late for Christmas suggestions, but this would surely be the ideal book for an architect or architectural student.

An architecture competition is like nothing that happens in any other field of human activity. All at the same time, hundreds of architects all over the country or the world, sit down and try to solve exactly the same problem. Past competitions, such as those for the British Houses of Parliament, the Chicago Tribune Tower or the League of Nations headquarters, have been gold mines for the architectural historians because of the way the entries summed up all the conflicting trends of their time. The Yale competition has that same kind of fascination.

Anyone who knows the Yale campus knows that during the 1950s and early 1960s the university put up so many stunning monumental buildings by so many "great" architects that Yale became a point of pilgrimage for architects the world over. It also got to a little like the world's fair, because the fine new buildings often seem to have very little to do with each other, and less with the old-fashioned Gothic and Georgian quadrangles that had given Yale, up to then, a stagey but pleasant and continuous scale and pattern that had unified the campus.

Charles Moore, the author of this book, who at the time was Chairman of Yale's department of architecture, thought with many others that the time had come to stop the monument building and find some contemporary equivalent to the quietly successful older buildings. A new headquarters for the mathe-



Venturi's winning Yale Math Building. Ugly? Ordinary? It's the best of the bunch.

matics department became the vehicle for this search when the university was persuaded to hold an open competition for the design.

A tougher design problem could hardly be imagined. In the first place, the new building would not be free-standing, but would be an addition to the existing math building, a vaguely Tudor pile called Leet Oliver Memorial Hall. On one side of the new building stretched a row of hodgepodge 20th century buildings that had nothing in common except height. On the other side, the new building would face Dana House, a national historic landmark in Italianate style, the first of a series of Victorian mansions.

In other words, the new math building would be the transition from the larger new buildings to the smaller older ones. At the same time it would have to span a railroad line and fulfill an extremely demanding program that included a library offices, classrooms and many other spaces.

Twenty-six of the designs that were submitted are reproduced in Moore's book, including the five finalists and the winner. The effect is flabbergasting.

It just doesn't seem possible that architects living in a single period could approach a problem in such insanely diverse ways. Some buildings are obvious derivations from masters such as Le Corbusier or Aalto or James Stirling, one is a mini Boston City Hall. Others reach out for their imagery to fields outside architecture that perhaps are seen as more chic and up-to-date, thus there are buildings that look like spacecraft or pieces of shiny plastic Italian furniture.

What it all proves is that there has never been a time, ever, when we were so unsure of what a building is supposed to be. Compared to these designers, the Victorians with their innumerable pseudo-historical styles were models of consistency.

That's the bad part, if it is bad. The good part is that almost every entry makes some kind of attempt to understand and solve the urban design problem of fitting the building into its difficult context.

As for the winner, Moore reports that not a single member of the nine-man jury voted for any project other than Venturi and Rauch's. A study of this fascinating book, among its other lessons, tends to support the verdict. Of the finalists, at least, Venturi's scheme is surely far and away the best. It terminates the row of new buildings with a curve like a moulding, a curve that also solves many interior planning problems while orienting most rooms to the best view. It's a solution that has simplicity of genius.

On the exterior, the building looks like a warehouse, and judging from this firm's other work, it probably will stay that way. But maybe now that they've shown they can come up a winner, they'll go soft on all that attention-getting "ugly and ordinary" stuff.

Whatever you think of the result, no one can quarrel with Moore's statement in the introduction that the Yale competition "provides an extraordinarily illuminating look at where we are 50 years into modern architecture." That fact makes this book an invaluable one.